

OMKAR THAWAKAR

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Researcher | Computer Vision | Multimodal AI | Large Language Models | Video Understanding

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

PhD researcher in Computer Vision and Multimodal AI with 6+ years of experience spanning foundational research and real-world deployment. Published 16+ papers at CVPR, ICCV, ECCV, ICLR, ACL, and EMNLP, with open-source work accumulating 1.2M+ HuggingFace downloads and 3.5K+ GitHub stars. Creator of MobiLlama (ICLR-SLLM 2025 Spotlight, Top 2%) — a lightweight, fully transparent LLM. Holder of a US patent in video instance segmentation. Seeking a Research Scientist or Research Engineer role where rigorous research meets scalable, real-world impact.

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Computer Vision

Aug 2023 – Spring 2027 | Abu Dhabi, UAE

Mohamed bin Zayed University of Artificial Intelligence (MBZUAI)

- Thesis: *Video Understanding with Large Multimodal Models* Advisor: Prof. Fahad Khan
- Research: Multimodal Learning, Vision-Language Models, Efficient LLMs, LLM Agents, Video Detection & Segmentation
- GPA: 3.74 / 4.00

B.Tech., Computer Science Engineering

Jun 2015 – Jul 2019 | Nanded, India

Shri Guru Gobind Singhji Institute of Engineering and Technology (SGGSIE&T)

- Coursework: Neural Networks, ML, Algorithms, OS, Cryptography, Distributed Systems, Computer Networking
- GPA: 8.7 / 10.0 **Best B.Tech Thesis Award**

RESEARCH & INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE

Research Scientist Intern — Multimodal Agents, Adobe Research

2026 | Ongoing

- Working on multimodal agentic systems integrating vision-language models with tool-use and retrieval-augmented generation (RAG).
- Collaborated with Adobe Research scientists to advance state-of-the-art in multimodal understanding and generation.

Researcher, Mohamed bin Zayed University of AI (MBZUAI)

May 2021 – Jul 2023 | Abu Dhabi, UAE

- Proposed dense video description for Composed Video Retrieval to retrieve target videos with desired changes.
- Achieved SOTA on video instance segmentation with transformer-based architecture — published at **ECCV 2022**.
- Achieved SOTA on 3D mitochondria instance segmentation using transformers (+3% accuracy) — **MICCAI 2023**.
- Pioneered open-world video instance segmentation using shallow features for novel object detection — **IJCV 2023**.

Machine Learning Engineer, Chefling India Pvt Ltd

Feb 2020 – May 2021 | Bangalore, India

- Deployed ML-powered recipe scraping service using Scrapy, achieving **87% accuracy** on complex web structures.
- Built recipe tagging service covering **70+ tag categories**, eliminating external dependency and reducing costs by **92%**.

Research Assistant, Indian Institute of Technology Ropar (IIT-Ropar)

Jan 2019 – Feb 2020 | Ropar, India

- Researched image/video super-resolution, moving object segmentation, and image restoration (haze, fog, lighting).
- Developed AI solutions for educational and commercial applications; won Best B.Tech Thesis Award for video super-resolution using GAN.

ENTREPRENEURSHIP

Co-Founder & CEO, Lawa.AI

Jul 2024 – Present | Abu Dhabi, UAE

- Secured **250K AED seed grant** (1st place, Khalifa Fund Entrepreneurship Comp.); scaled to **\$130K+ ARR** in year one.
- Led R&D for multimodal LLM products, agentic retrieval pipelines, and production-grade Agentic-AI deployments.
- Represented Lawa.AI at **ITU-WTSA 2024 Innovation Xchange** (New Delhi) as an emerging UAE startup.

Co-Founder & CTO, Nutrigenics.Care

Jan 2024 – Present | Abu Dhabi, UAE

- Raised **\$100K+ in grants** incl. **Microsoft Founders Hub** (\$150K technical support); 1st place at Microsoft Pitch Day.
- Led end-to-end development of the Nutrition-GPT AI engine; partnered with two healthcare organizations for clinical validation and adaptation in the hospitals for specific groups.

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

16 total — CVPR, ICCV, ECCV, ICLR, ACL, EMNLP, MICCAI, IJCV

- **EvoLMM: Self-Evolving Large Multimodal Models with Continuous Rewards** [CVPR 2026]
- **CoVR-R: Reason-Aware Composed Video Retrieval** [CVPR 2026]
- **Thinking Beyond Labels: Vocabulary-Free Fine-Grained Recognition using Reasoning-Augmented LMMs** [CVPR 2026]
- **Beyond Simple Edits: Composed Video Retrieval with Dense Modifications** [ICCV 2025]
- **LlamaV-o1: Rethinking Step-by-Step Visual Reasoning in LLMs** [ACL 2025]
150+ citations · 50K+ HF Downloads
- **MobiLlama: Towards Accurate and Lightweight Fully Transparent GPT** [ICLR 2025]
Spotlight - Top 2%, ICLR-SLLM · 50+ citations · 352K+ HF Downloads · 600+ Github stars
- **All Languages Matter: Evaluating LMMs on Culturally Diverse 100 Languages** [CVPR 2025]
CVPR 2025 Highlight · 50+ citations · 11K+ HF Downloads
- **CAMEL-Bench: A Comprehensive Arabic LMM Benchmark** [NAACL 2025]
- **Composed Video Retrieval via Enriched Context and Discriminative Embeddings** [CVPR 2024]
- **XrayGPT: Chest radiographs summarization using large medical vision-language models** [ACL-W 2024]
340+ citations · 390K+ HF Downloads · 500+ Github stars
- **Video Instance Segmentation in an Open-World** [IJCV 2024]
- **3D Mitochondria Instance Segmentation with Spatio-Temporal Transformers** [MICCAI 2023]
- **Video Instance Segmentation via Multi-Scale Spatio-Temporal Split Attention Transformer** [ECCV 2022]
- **System and Method for Video Instance Segmentation via Multi-Scale Spatio-Temporal Split Attention Transformer, Patent #12499573, Published Dec 2025** [US Patent]

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Research Areas: Computer Vision, Multimodal Learning, Vision-Language Models, Video Understanding, LLMs, Agentic AI, Dense Retrieval, Image/Video Segmentation

Deep Learning: PyTorch, TensorFlow, HuggingFace Transformers, LoRA/QLoRA, RLHF, DPO, RAG, Diffusion Models

Programming: Python, R, Java, C

MLOps / Cloud: AWS, Azure, Google Cloud Platform, Docker, MLflow, BigQuery

Data & Web: PySpark, NumPy, Pandas, Matplotlib, Scikit-learn, Flask, Django, React-JS, MongoDB, SQLite

HONORS & AWARDS

- **Winner Lawa.AI — National Grant Program for Culture and Creativity** — 100K AED grant, MoC Nov 2025
- **1st Place — Khalifa Fund Entrepreneurship Competition** — 250K AED startup grant, ADBW Dec 2024
- **ICLR-W 2025 Spotlight** — MobiLlama selected as Top 2% paper at SLLM Workshop Feb 2025
- **Microsoft Founders Hub Grant** — Nutrigenics.Care awarded \$150K in technical support Jul 2024
- **1st Place — Sandook-AI-Watan Student Pitch Competition** — 30K AED startup grant Nov 2024
- **1st Place — Pitch Day with Microsoft** — MBZUAI Incubation & Entrepreneurship Center May 2024
- **Best B.Tech Thesis Award** — Video Super-Resolution using Recurrent GAN, SGGSIE&T May 2019
- **Best Research Paper — IC3NS-2018** — Application of ML Algorithms for IPM Device May 2018

ACADEMIC SERVICE

- **Reviewer:** CVPR, ICCV, ECCV, IEEE, CVF, Springer — 40+ papers reviewed from top-tier venues Jul 2022 – Present
- **Teaching Assistant,** MBZUAI — Department of Computer Vision August 2023 – Dec 2025

REFERENCES

Prof. Fahad Khan (Primary PhD Advisor)
Deputy Chair CV, MBZUAI fahad.khan@mbzuai.ac.ae

Prof. Mubarak Shah (Mentor / Collaborator)
University of Central Florida shah@crcv.ucf.edu

Prof. Timothy Baldwin (Mentor / Collaborator)
Provost, MBZUAI timothy.baldwin@mbzuai.ac.ae

Dr. Salman Khan (PhD Co-Advisor)
Assoc Prof, MBZUAI salman.khan@mbzuai.ac.ae